

The mid-1970s kicked off what would become a continuing quest for speed as countries followed in Japan's footsteps. British Rail began its High Speed Train trials in 1973, which continue to hold the diesel speed record of 238 km/h. In 1981, France launched its Train à Grande Vitesse (TGV) with a line running from Paris to Lyon, followed by Germany in 1991 with its InterCity Express. New tram systems opened in some places, such as the tram-train services in Karlsruhe, Germany in 1992. These innovative vehicles had the capacity to run on local rail and tramways.

The change in the world order with the end of the Cold War and unification of Germany, meant the building of new lines even as the East and West Germany railway systems merged to become the Deutsche Bahn. Britain witnessed a sea change as its Parliament voted for privatization in 1993, following which new companies took over and developed. The year 1994 proved to be iconic with the opening of the Channel Tunnel connecting France and Britain for the first time.

The future beckons

With crucial advancements in speed, the emergence of energy-efficient locomotives, and growing emphasis on comfort and luxury travel, the railways have succeeded in reinventing themselves to become important in the travel industry once again. Metros have become a viable alternative in city travel as operators focus on automation, such as in Dubai, which launched the world's longest fully automated metro at 75 km, in 2010.

The quest for higher speeds continues to drive operators. The Maglev or magnetic levitation train made its presence felt in 2003 after an experimental train reached a speed of 581 km/h. A year later, the world's first commercial high-speed Maglev began operations in Shanghai, China. In 2007, France tested an experimental TGV which set a new world record for conventional-wheeled trains at 575 km/h.

Connections continued to be made as in 2006 when train services started to Lhasa, Tibet. The line, which passes the Kunlun mountains, reaches an altitude of more than 5000 m, and is the highest railway service in the world. The railways are here to stay.